

Charles Taragin

PRINCIPAL ECONOMIST

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Antitrust and banking economist with over 15 years of experience leading high-profile merger investigations at the Federal Reserve Board, Federal Trade Commission, and Department of Justice. Specialist in horizontal and vertical merger simulation, spatial market definition, and industrial organization. Developer of the standard open-source R packages for antitrust simulation and policy analysis. U.S. Citizen.

EXPERIENCE

Federal Reserve Board

Washington DC

PRINCIPAL ECONOMIST

September 2022 - present

- Lead the economic analysis of bank mergers and divestitures, including the high-profile Capital One / Discover merger (joint Board and DOJ investigation).

Federal Trade Commission

Washington DC

ECONOMIST

June 2019 - September 2022

- Collaborated with attorneys to model and quantify competitive effects in merger investigations, including vertical integration in the NVIDIA / ARM semiconductor merger (FTC challenge).

Antitrust Division, U.S. Department of Justice

Washington DC

ECONOMIST

September 2007 - May 2019

- Served as an economist on major merger investigations and litigations, including Anthem / Cigna (health insurance), American Airlines / US Airways (airlines), National CineMedia / Screenvision (cinema advertising), Twin America ("hop-on, hop-off" tour buses), Standard Parking / Central Parking (parking facilities), and radio station advertising mergers.
- Modeled market-wide pricing and welfare impacts of Washer and Steel tariffs and import quotas proposed during the first Trump administration.
- Authored core code and mathematical frameworks (in R and Stata) for horizontal merger, tariff, and quota simulations used standardly in Antitrust Division investigations.
- Designed and coded interactive web interfaces for merger and tariff simulation tools.
- Designed and maintained massive databases (exceeding 10 TB) to support complex antitrust investigations and federal court litigation.

PUBLICATIONS

1. Taragin, C., & Taylhardat, M. (2025). A distance-based algorithm for defining antitrust markets. *Finance Research Letters*, 86, 108972. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.fr1.2025.108972>
2. Benson, D., Bord, V., Garner, A., & Taragin, C. (2023). *Size and survival of entrants to retail banking*. Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System; FEDS Notes. <https://doi.org/10.17016/2380-7172.3345>
3. Panhans, M. T., & Taragin, C. (2023). Consequences of model choice in predicting horizontal merger effects. *International Journal of Industrial Organization*, 89, 102986. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijindorg.2023.102986>
4. Vita, M., Brand, K., Larson-Koester, M., Petek, N., Taragin, C., Violette, W., & Wood, D. H. (2022). Economics at the FTC: Estimating harm from deception and analyzing mergers. *Review of Industrial Organization*, 61(4), 405–438. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11151-022-09883-w>
5. Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. (2021). Simulating mergers in a vertical supply chain with bargaining. *The RAND Journal of Economics*, 52(3), 596–632. <https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1111/1756-2171.12385>
6. Froeb, L. M., Mares, V., Tschantz, S., & Taragin, C. (2018). The simple algebra of surplus in private values open auctions: A nested logit merger model. *Economics Bulletin*, 38(4), 2304–2312. <https://ideas.repec.org/a/eb1/ecbull/eb-18-00431.html>
7. Froeb, L. M., Pittman, R. W., Taragin, C. S., Tschantz, S., & Werden, G. J. (2018). Economics at the Antitrust Division: 2017–2018. *Review of Industrial Organization*, 53(4), 637–651. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11151-018-9662-8>
8. Borzekowski, R., Thomadsen, R., & Taragin, C. (2009). Competition and price discrimination in the market for mailing lists. *QME*, 7(2), 147–179. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11129-009-9050-7>

UNDER REVIEW

1. Taragin, C., Wallace, B., & Watkins, E. (2025). *Financial structure and mergers* (No. 2025-080; Finance and Economics Discussion Series). Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System. <https://doi.org/10.17016/FEDS.2025.080>
2. Hosken, D., Larson-Koester, M., & Taragin, C. (2025). *Labor and product market effects of mergers*.

IN PROGRESS

1. Benson, D., Loudermilk, M., & Taragin, C. (2026). *Merger screening under uncertain conduct*.
2. Benson, D., Garner, A., Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. S. (2026). *Merger effects and efficiencies under uncertainty: Evidence from supreme court decisions on banking*.
3. Loudermilk, M., Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. (2023). *Beyond “Horizontal” and “Vertical”: The welfare effects of complex integration* (No. 2023-005; Finance and Economics Discussion Series). Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System. <https://doi.org/10.17016/FEDS.2023.005>

EDUCATION

Economics

PHD

University of Michigan

2007

Economics

MASTERS

University of Michigan

2004

Public Policy

MASTERS

University of Chicago

2000

Economics

University of Chicago

BACHELORS

1999

PRESENTATIONS

FEDERAL TRADE COMMISSION

11/2025

DC IO DAY

5/2019

INTERNATIONAL INDUSTRIAL ORGANIZATION CONFERENCE	4/2019
FEDERAL TRADE COMMISSION	6/2018, 7/2018
INTERNATIONAL COMPETITION NETWORK	2018
INTERNATIONAL INDUSTRIAL ORGANIZATION CONFERENCE	2018
FEDERAL COMMUNICATION COMMISSION	8/2018, 2013
U.S. DEPARTMENT OF JUSTICE	2012, 2017

R SOFTWARE PACKAGES

ANTITRUST

- A collection of tools for antitrust practitioners, including merger simulation models, market definition, and equilibrium pricing. Calibrates demand parameters and simulates mergers under various differentiated products demand systems including logit, nested logit, ces, and aids.

TRADE

- A collection of tools for trade policy analysis. Provides trade policy practitioners with a tractable framework for simulating the effects of tariffs, quotas, and other trade policy measures on market outcomes.

COMPETITIONTOOLBOX

- A graphical user interface for the antitrust and trade R packages. Provides an interactive interface for conducting merger simulations, market definition analysis, and trade policy analysis without requiring R programming knowledge.

SERVICE

ACTING ADVISOR TO COMMISSIONER NOAH PHILLIPS	2021
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- Served as Acting Advisor to Commissioner Noah Phillips for three months.

US DOJ/KFTC KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE PROGRAM	2018
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- Organized, co-authored and co-taught a 3 day training program for new economists at the Korean Free Trade Commission (KFTC). The purpose of this program was to train KFTC economists in how to analyze horizontal mergers.

ALGORITHMIC DOCUMENT REVIEW	2017
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- Trained a series of machine learning classifiers to predict if a document is pertinent to an investigation. Once these models have been fully tested, they will greatly reduce the time needed to review the massive amount of documents received by the Antitrust Division.

R TRAINING	2012 - present
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- Authored and co-taught a series of short courses for Economists and Research Analysts on R. Covered topics included: data analysis, plotting, regression analysis, mapping, interfacing with databases, and antitrust analysis.

AWARDS

TEAM SPECIAL ACHIEVEMENT AWARD FOR WORK ON CAPITAL ONE/DISCOVER MERGER	2025
EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR POSITIVE EXTERNALITY	2019
TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON ANTHEM/CIGNA LITIGATION	2017
EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR EXTRAORDINARY ACHIEVEMENT	2016
TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON NATIONAL CINEMEDIA/SCREENVISION LITIGATION	2015
TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON AMERICAN/US AIRWAYS LITIGATION	2014
EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR PUSHING FRONTIERS	2010

TECHNICAL SKILLS & COMPETENCIES

METHODS

- Merger Simulation, Structural Econometrics, Spatial Market Definition, Bargaining Models

PROGRAMMING

- R (Core Package Developer), Python, C++, Java

DATABASES

- PostgreSQL, DuckDB, SQLite, PostGIS, MySQL

AI & LLM TOOLS

- Claude Code, OpenAI APIs, Prompt Engineering

MARKUP

- Markdown, LaTeX